Structural Vulnerability and Academic Trajectories of Indigenous Migrant Students at the Autonomous University of Sinaloa

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Introduction

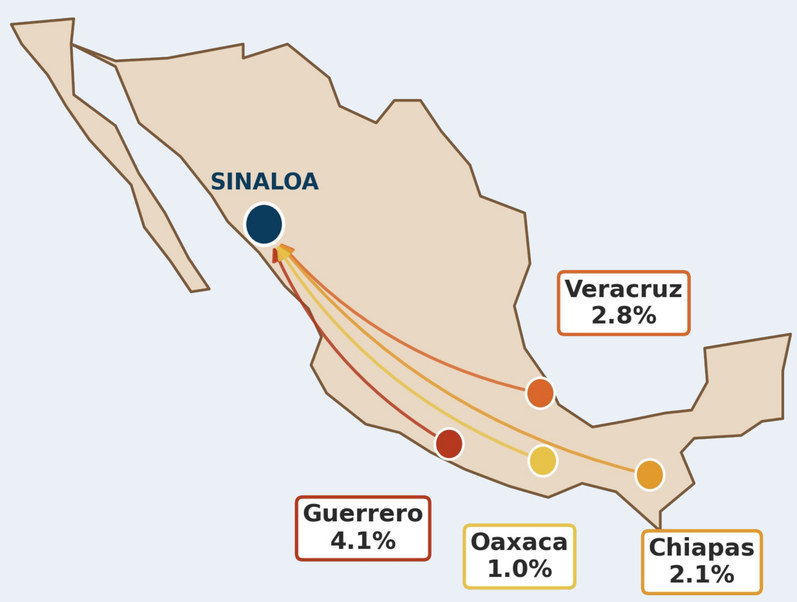
- Poverty, inequality, and marginalization drive Indigenous families from southern Mexico to migrate in search of better living conditions.
- Indigenous youth move to northern states such as Sinaloa to pursue higher education amid limited opportunities in their home communities.
- They face exclusion, discrimination, racism, epistemic violence, and microaggressions —forms of structural vulnerability.
- They experience vulnerability both at origin and destination, with limited support programs and precarious, informal employment.

Structural Vulnerability

"A positionality that imposes physical and emotional suffering on specific groups and individuals in a structured manner, resulting from class-based economic exploitation and cultural, gender/sexual, and racial discrimination, as well as related processes of devalued subject formation."

— English translation of Piñones, Quesada & Holmes (2019, p. 2)

Origins of Migration



States of origin with the highest shares of northbound migrants whose destination is Sinaloa (INEGI, 2024).

Research Question

How does structural vulnerability shape the academic trajectories of Indigenous migrant students at UAS in Culiacán, Sinaloa, Mexico?

Research Objective

To analyze how structural vulnerability shapes Indigenous migrant students' academic trajectories (admission, retention, and graduation) at UAS, and the strategies they use to address it, from an intersectional perspective.

Methodology

1. **Literature review**
Studies of Indigenous students: mostly qualitative research in higher education, with two studies at the high school level.

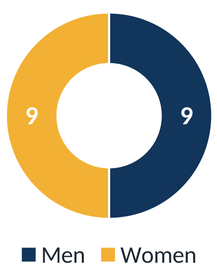
2. **Exploratory study**
Quantitative approach and explanatory paradigm. Online survey (Google Forms).

3. **Sample and instrument**
18 participants (9 men, 9 women) · 6 sections, 50 questions covering economic, family, cultural, and institutional dimensions.

Findings

Exploratory survey · n = 18 Indigenous migrant students

Participant Gender



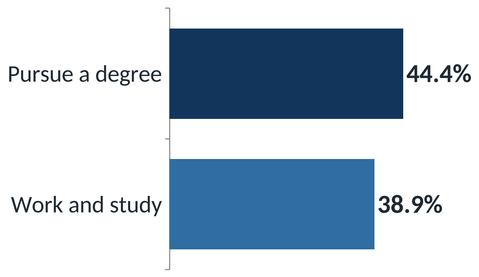
Language

44.4% speak their Indigenous language and Spanish

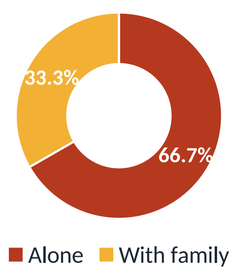
27.8% do not speak it but understand it

67% do not feel free to speak their language without shame or fear of rejection

Reason for Migration



Who Did They Migrate With?



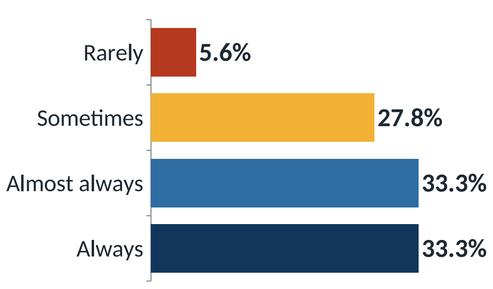
Cultural Dimension

>50% have felt judged because of their clothing or appearance

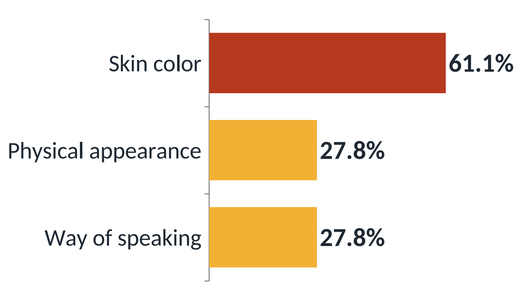
38.9% have never felt judged or criticized

61.1% have only sometimes been able to freely practice their traditions

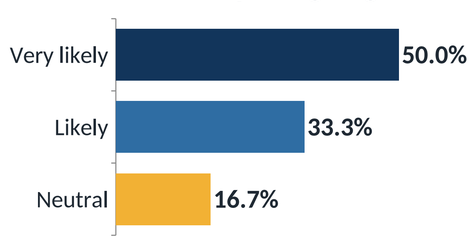
Equal Educational Opportunities



Discrimination Based on...



Likelihood of Completing Degree



No respondents selected "unlikely" or "not at all likely."

These are preliminary exploratory findings. The research is in its initial stage and results may change as the study progresses.

RELEVANCE TO EAAMO

1. Indigenous youth migrate across states to pursue university degrees and improve their living conditions.
2. Intervention proposals and action strategies can highlight the value of education in Indigenous communities.
3. Collaboration with the public sector can support inclusive policies, scholarships, and programs that promote enrollment and retention.

References: Chávez (2008), Revista de la Educación Superior, 37(4) · Dietz, Pérez & Donnelly (2025) · DOF (2026; 2019), National Development Plan · INEGI (2025; 2026), Multidimensional Poverty and Poverty Lines · INPI (2021; 2025) · IWGIA & ILO (2021), Indigenous Navigator · Piñones, Quesada & Holmes (2019), Salud Colectiva.